

‘THE KEY IS TO LEARN TO SURVIVE’

Raymond Chairman & MD Gautam Hari Singhania on the way ahead for the textiles major

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PHOTOS BY BANDEEP SINGH

PERSEVERANCE, grit, strong leadership skills, high risk appetite, and a flashy and fast lifestyle don't necessarily go well with naiveté. But Gautam Hari Singhania, 58, has shades of them all. No matter what you think of the Chairman & MD of Raymond, the fact is that he has shown exemplary leadership skills in the toughest of times to pull his organisation out of the losses wrought by Covid-19, and onto a sustained growth trajectory. In a candid conversation with *Business Today*, Singhania lays bare his strategy for Raymond's turnaround. Edited excerpts:



The pandemic was a

bad time for Indian industry. Are there any instances that stand out for you as symbols of what happened and what changed the company or you as a person?

You're right, the pandemic was an extremely difficult time, especially for a company like ours where retail was closed, we had no revenue, plus we had manufacturing on the side. So, we had people to carry, interest cost... it was a very difficult time. There's a very famous saying. It's called success is relative—more the success, more the relatives. But when you don't have success, those same people disappear. There was a day when, for a group of this size, a private

limited bank refused to roll over an existing loan of ₹5 crore because it said it won't get it [the money] back. But we had the conviction that we will make it happen... that this, too, shall pass. And we put our heads down, rolled up our sleeves and did what we had to do. And I'm happy to say today things have changed dramatically. So, the pandemic taught us a lot of things, also showed us who's on our side and who's not. What really stood by us is our trade, our dealers, our relationships. We did away with our fair-weather friends. The same people now stand in line looking for business again, but obviously, it's not going to be. But you know, such

is life. You asked me what I learnt? You learn to survive. The key is to learn to survive.



Would you say that the pandemic has made you and Raymond stronger than before?

Infinitely stronger. Look at the amount of cost we took out of the system. We re-engineered ourselves on doing business. And in the pandemic, in three years, we built a very strong real estate business as a counter strategy, as insurance, for balancing if one went bad and if one went good. In less than three years, at 11:30 am on December 10 (2022; this interview was taken on December 5), we're